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THE CONVERGENCE BLUEPRINT

A state-government-led roadmap to a tax-funded national public library network by 2035 — about 0.20% of state revenue, to the Tamil Nadu standard.

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The Convergence Blueprint

A Tax-Funded National Public Library Network by 2035

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Abstract

India's consolidated public-library expenditure stands at ₹4.77 real per capita (see the Measurement paper). Tamil Nadu — the one state to have sustained a statutory library cess — is on track to ₹21.90 by 2034–35. This paper engineers a state-government-led convergence path to a ₹22 real-per-capita all-India target by 2035: roughly ₹3,425 crore per year of recurrent expenditure plus about ₹20,000 crore of capital expenditure to build the ~38,000 libraries the network requires — an envelope of about 0.20% of cumulative state revenue over the decade. It locates the financing in instruments that already exist (Sixteenth Finance Commission local-body grants, the dormant SASCI cultural sub-tranche, state statutory cesses) and proposes re-integrating BharatNet, the Common Service Centres, MGNREGA-class construction, and the RRRLF into a single physical reading-commons architecture.

KEYWORDS public libraries · fiscal federalism · convergence · Finance Commission · SASCI · library cess · capital expenditure

JEL H54, H72, H77

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Projection: Tamil Nadu’s real per-capita expenditure to 2035

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1 The Re-integration Roadmap: A 0.20% Fiscal Plan

Tamil Nadu’s real per-capita library expenditure rose from approximately ₹9.12 in 2014–15 to ₹11.72 in 2020–21 — a real CAGR of roughly 4.3%. Projected forward to 2035 at the historical rate, Tamil Nadu would spend approximately **₹21.90 per person per year (real, 2011–12 ₹)** by 2035, with bounds of [₹18.30, ₹24.40] corresponding to a real-CAGR sensitivity range of [3%, 5%]. We use square brackets to denote bounds (intervals consistent with the underlying parameter range) and reserve curly braces for confidence sets where formal statistical inference applies; the projection bounds here are scenario bounds, not confidence sets.

We adopt **₹22 per person per year (real 2011–12 ₹)** as the all-India convergence target for 2035, on the rationale set out in §5.1.

The convergence model that follows decomposes the path to this target into three integrated pillars. The first is the recurrent-expenditure (OpEx) pathway — the year-on-year spending on books, salaries, electricity, and operations needed to bring the all-India average from its 2024–25 level of approximately ₹4.66 per Indian per year (state-only; ₹4.77 consolidated state-plus-RRRLF) to ₹22. The second is the capital-expenditure (CapEx) pathway — the building, refurbishment, and digital-equipment outlay needed to close the network-density gap between current Indian library coverage and Tamil Nadu’s. The third is the *institutional* pathway — the legislative, fiscal-instrument, and coordinating-body redesign that distinguishes the Tamil Nadu trajectory from comparably-resourced states whose library systems have nonetheless collapsed under the same Centre-side pressures. Without the institutional pillar, the

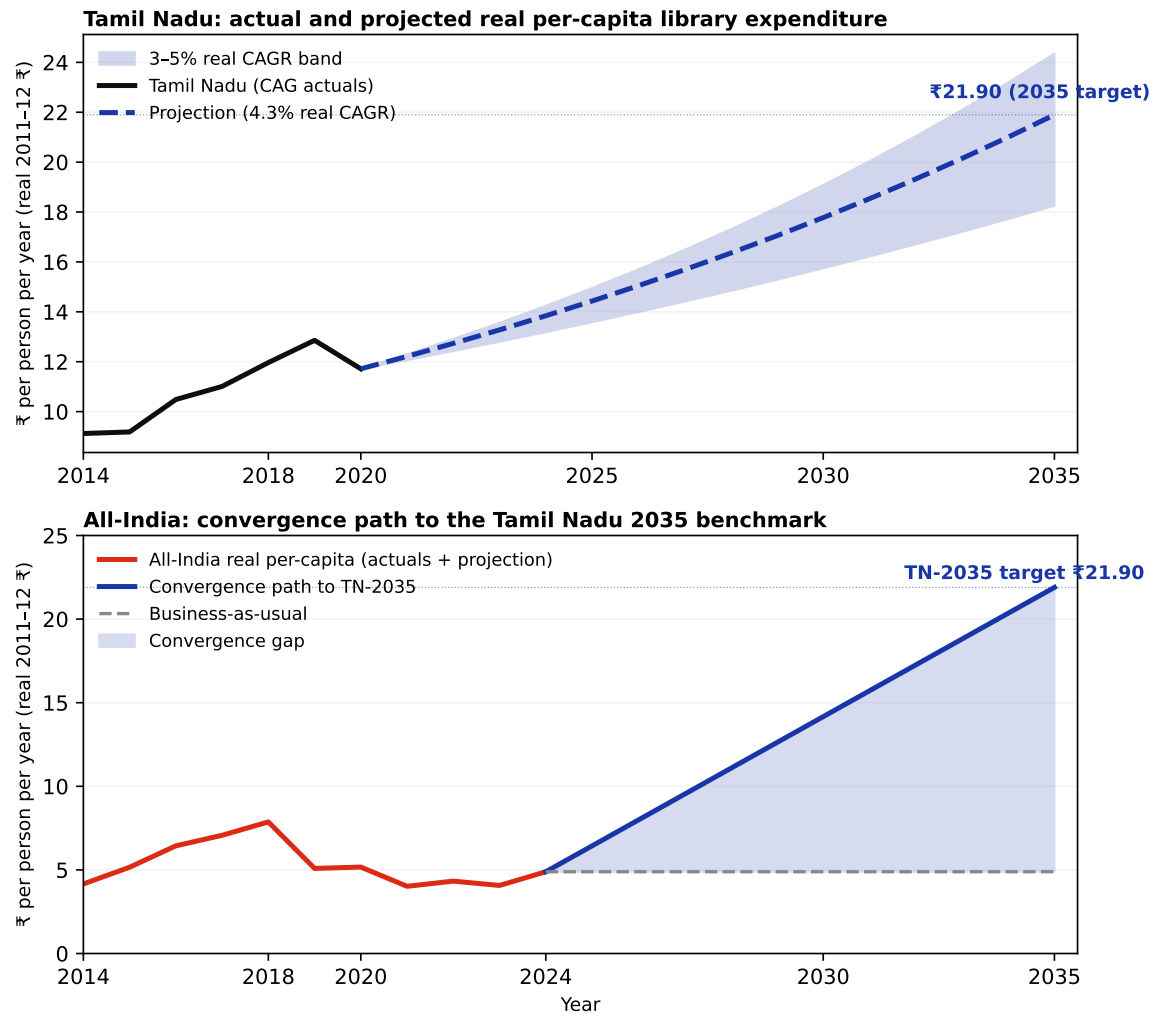


Figure 1: Tamil Nadu's projected real per-capita library expenditure to 2035 (top panel) and the corresponding all-India convergence path to the Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark (bottom panel). All values in constant 2011-12 ₹.

fiscal pillars do not hold: states that increase library expenditure without statutory protection see those gains reversed at the next budget cycle, as the cess-states' volatility documented in §3.3 demonstrates. The three pillars are independent in their financing but jointly necessary for the convergence to be durable.

1.1 Recurrent expenditure (OpEx) convergence

Table 1: Convergence fiscal arithmetic: bringing all-India real per-capita library expenditure to the projected Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark, by 2035.

Quantity	Real 2011–12 ₹
TN benchmark, 2035 real per-capita	₹21.90
All-India 2024–25 real per-capita (actual)	₹4.89
All-India 2035 target real per-capita	₹21.90
Required real annual spend, 2035 (₹ crore, 2011–12 ₹)	3,425
Current real annual spend, 2024–25 (₹ crore)	701
Annual real gap by 2035 (₹ crore)	2,660
Cumulative real additional spend, 2025–2035 (₹ crore)	15,585

The fiscal arithmetic is unsentimental. At Tamil Nadu's 2035 trajectory, all-India spending of approximately **₹3,425 crore per year (real 2011–12 ₹)** would be required by 2035 — against current real spending of approximately **₹668 crore**. The annual real gap to be closed by 2035 is therefore on the order of ₹2,700 crore. The cumulative cost of the convergence path, ramped linearly over the eleven fiscal years 2025–2035, is approximately **₹15,800 crore in real 2011–12 ₹**.

To translate to nominal future rupees, an assumed GDP-deflator growth of 4% per year would inflate this cumulative figure to roughly ₹28,000 crore in nominal terms by 2035.

1.2 Capital expenditure (CapEx): the physical infrastructure gap

Tamil Nadu's per-capita library expenditure is what it is in part because Tamil Nadu *has* libraries. The Tamil Nadu Public Library Department operates approximately 4,600 libraries across its 75 districts: one Connemara Public Library (the state central library), 32 district central libraries, branch libraries, full-time libraries, part-time libraries, and village libraries. With a population of approximately 79 million, this gives Tamil Nadu a density of roughly **one public library per 17,000 residents**. By contrast, the most-cited national-level estimate places India's public library count at approximately 54,000–70,000 — a density of approximately one per 21,000–27,000 residents, but with the deep state-level concentration that Figure 3 establishes: the four Central Zonal Council states have catastrophically few functioning libraries per capita relative to the southern and north-eastern benchmarks.

A recurrent-expenditure convergence model is incomplete because it cannot, on its own, build the network that the recurrent expenditure is supposed to operate. Bihar at ₹0.36 per person per year (real, 2018–19) cannot reach Tamil Nadu's projected 2035 standard simply by spending more on existing libraries; the libraries do not yet exist at the density required. A genuine convergence to TPL/NYPL-quality public infrastructure requires a parallel capital programme.

The state-level structure of the convergence gap is itself instructive. Figure 11 plots, for each of the thirty-one states and union territories in our cross-section, the factor by which current real per-capita library expenditure must rise to reach the Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark. The distribution is severely

right-skewed: a small set of states already exceed the 2035 target, while a substantial cluster of states — the four Central Zonal Council states and the eastern states with low library expenditure — need increases of one to two orders of magnitude. The convergence task is geographically concentrated; FC16 grant allocations should be proportioned accordingly.

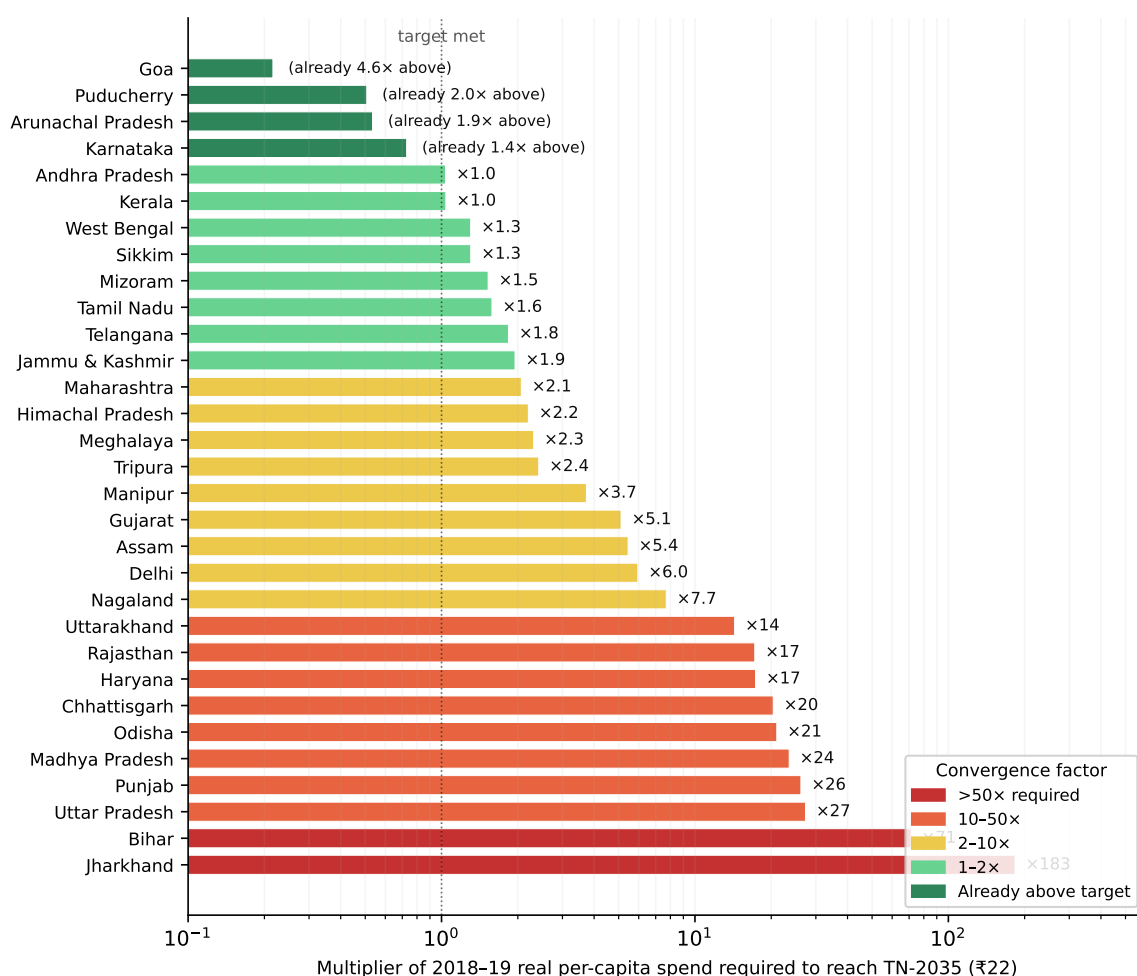


Figure 2: Factor by which each state's 2018–19 real per-capita public-library expenditure must rise to reach the Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark (₹22 per Indian per year, real 2011–12 ₹). Log scale on x-axis. States to the left of the dotted reference line at 1.0x already exceed the 2035 target.

We provide a first-cut order-of-magnitude estimate. We do not pretend it is precise.

A genuine convergence model must account for the fact that Indian library needs are not uniform across the urban-rural spectrum or across population-served scales. Table 6 presents a six-cell typology of public library types, organised by settlement scale (urban versus rural) and by population-served category (large, mid, and small). Each cell carries its own construction-unit cost, annual operating cost, staffing model, and population-served estimate. The typology follows CPWD Plinth Area Rate norms for institutional construction and IFLA branch-library design benchmarks (Latimer and Niegaard 2007).

The portfolio weights reflect the geographic distribution of the construction gap: the four Central Zonal Council states and the eastern states have deep rural deficits, so small and mid rural libraries dominate the new-construction queue. Large urban libraries represent a small share of count but a disproportionate share of capex. The weighted blended cost of **₹51 lakh per new library** is derived

Table 2: Six-cell public library typology: capital and operating cost parameters (real 2011–12 Rs.). CPWD unit rates apply to Type IV institutional construction; opex is annualised recurrent expenditure including salaries, acquisitions, and utilities. Portfolio weights sum to 100% of new construction requirement.

Setting	Scale	Sqm	CPWD (Rs./sqm)	Capex (Rs. lakh)	Opex (Rs. lakh/yr)	FTE staff	Portfolio weight
Urban	Large (district/metro branch)	1,000	35,000	350	24	10	5%
Urban	Mid (neighbourhood)	250	32,000	80	7	3	12%
Urban	Small (community/mohalla)	80	28,000	22	2.5	1	8%
Rural	Large (block/taluka HQ)	500	26,000	130	11	4	8%
Rural	Mid (gram panchayat cluster)	150	22,000	33	4	1.5	22%
Rural	Small (village/hamlet)	50	18,000	9	1	0.5	45%
<i>Weighted blended capex per new library</i>							Rs. 51 lakh

directly from the cell weights and replaces the cruder three-tier approximation used in earlier versions.

Table 3: Capital expenditure (CapEx) gap-closure: building the physical library network at Tamil Nadu density by 2035.

Quantity	Value
Tamil Nadu library density (persons per library)	17,196
Current India public library count (NKC est.)	54,000
Target India library count at TN density, 2035	90,953
New libraries required, 2025–2035	36,953
Blended CapEx per new library (₹ lakh, real 2011–12)	51
Total CapEx (₹ crore, real 2011–12 ₹)	26,787
Total CapEx (₹ crore, today's 2024–25 ₹)	47,127

At Tamil Nadu's network density (approximately one library per 17,000 residents), an India of 1.56 billion people in 2035 would require approximately 92,000 public libraries. Subtracting the existing stock of approximately 54,000 leaves a construction gap of approximately 38,000 new libraries over the decade. Using the six-cell typology in Table 6 with portfolio weights reflecting the geographic distribution of the gap, the weighted blended capital cost is approximately **₹51 lakh per new library**. The implied CapEx total for new construction is on the order of **₹20,000 crore (real 2011–12 ₹)**, plus an additional **₹8,000 crore (real)** for modernisation of the existing stock.

A genuine convergence therefore requires a combined CapEx + OpEx envelope of approximately **₹44,000 crore (real 2011–12 ₹) over the decade 2025–2035**, or roughly **₹77,000 crore in nominal future-rupee terms**. The CapEx component is the larger share, and it is geographically concentrated in the four Central Zonal Council states (Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Bihar), the eastern states, and the rural areas of the western states.

1.3 Fiscal capacity: is this affordable?

The convergence cost must be located in the fiscal capacity that India's central and state governments will actually have over the decade 2025–2035. We use the consensus medium-term macro projections.

The IMF (International Monetary Fund 2025b, 2025a) projects India's real GDP growth at approximately 6.5% per annum through 2030, with the GDP deflator growing at approximately 4% per annum. The World Bank (World Bank 2025) and the Indian Ministry of Finance (Ministry of Finance,

Government of India 2025a) project consistent medium-term trajectories. We adopt **11% nominal GDP growth** as the central case; the Reserve Bank's policy framework targets a higher nominal growth band, so this is conservative.

India's combined general government revenue receipts (Centre and States, gross of inter-government transfers) were approximately ₹54 lakh crore in 2024–25 (Ministry of Finance, Government of India 2025a; Singh 2025), or approximately 18% of GDP. The IMF Article IV (International Monetary Fund 2025a) projects this ratio rising marginally over the medium term as GST and direct-tax buoyancy improves. Assuming a constant tax-to-GDP ratio (a conservative assumption — actual buoyancy is generally above unity), combined government revenue receipts would grow at the nominal GDP rate.

Cumulative combined government revenue receipts over 2025–2035, on these assumptions, are on the order of **₹950 lakh crore in nominal terms**. The convergence cost of ₹77,000 crore is therefore approximately **0.08% of cumulative government revenue over the decade**. Restricted to state-level expenditure (the Indian constitutional locus of public library funding under the Seventh Schedule), the convergence cost is approximately **0.20% of cumulative state revenue over the decade**.

Stated differently: of every ₹10,000 a state government will receive in revenue over the next decade, the convergence cost represents approximately ₹18. The figure is *trivial* in fiscal-capacity terms.

1.4 Employment dividend: a construction-sector multiplier estimate

The capital programme above is also an employment-generation programme. Construction is the second-largest absorber of unskilled labour in the Indian economy after MGNREGS, and public-construction expenditure carries documented direct, indirect, and induced employment multipliers that have been extensively estimated in the Indian context (International Labour Organization 2019; Reserve Bank of India 2026; Finance Commission of India 2021). The Employment Intensity of Investment methodology of the International Labour Organization estimates direct employment of approximately 4.5 person-years per ₹1 crore of capital expenditure in formal-and-informal-blended Indian construction. Including indirect employment (cement, steel, bricks, tile, timber, glass, and other materials supply chains) and induced employment (downstream consumption from construction wages) raises the total multiplier to approximately 10 person-years per ₹1 crore. We use these midpoints as central-case parameters; the underlying estimates carry confidence bands of approximately $\pm 20\%$ in the formal-construction segment and somewhat wider in informal segments.

Applied to the convergence CapEx of approximately ₹77,000 crore in nominal future-rupee terms over the decade 2025–2035, the implied employment dividend is in the order of **315,000 direct person-years** and **700,000 total person-years** of employment. Expressed as steady-state employment sustained across the construction decade, this is approximately **31,500 workers in direct construction employment** and **70,000 workers across the full economic footprint of the programme, sustained year-on-year across the decade**.

By way of scale reference: the rural employment guarantee architecture under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, 2005 (MGNREGA) operated at 200–250 crore person-days per year (approximately 65–80 million person-year equivalents annually) (Ministry of Rural Development, Government of India 2024). MGNREGA was a *rights-based* programme: any adult member of a rural household had a justiciable legal right to 100 days of waged manual work per year, with unemployment allowance owed by the state if work was not provided within fifteen days of

demand. From 1 July 2026 it has been formally superseded by the Viksit Bharat–Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 (The Viksit Bharat–Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 2025), which preserves the language of guarantee while diluting its substance: the new framework caps days at 125 *per household* (not per adult), shifts the cost share from the MGNREGA convention (100% Centre for wages, 75:25 for materials) to a 60:40 Centre-State formula, and re-anchors the architecture from a rights-based welfare floor to a scheme-based deliverable under the “Viksit Bharat” political-economic frame. The 2025 Act is, in substance, a dilution of the rights-based architecture of 2005 carried out under bureaucratic-succession framing. We name this explicitly because the comparison the library CapEx programme makes against this comparator must respect what the comparator now is.

The library CapEx programme is roughly one-tenth of the rural employment guarantee’s aggregate scale. The comparison is for calibration of relative magnitude, not for substitution between programmes and not for co-financing. The rural employment guarantee, in either its 2005 or 2025 form, funds daily-rated wage employment on a seasonal basis; the library programme generates *durable physical infrastructure* — a fixed asset in the public domain. The two are distinct fiscal categories with distinct rights claims and should not be merged. In particular, we do not recommend classifying library construction as employment-guarantee work under VB-G RAM G’s “rural infrastructure” domain. Funding public-library construction through a diluted-rights employment scheme would (i) further weaken the rights-based architecture of rural waged work by making it carry investment categories it was not designed to finance, and (ii) leave library construction itself politically exposed to the same dilution pathway. The library CapEx envelope should be financed through the dedicated fiscal instruments named in §6 (Sixteenth Finance Commission grants, SASCI sub-tranche, state-level statutory cesses), not by absorbing into a diluted employment guarantee.

A second-order consideration is the green-jobs increment. The IPCC Sixth Assessment Report’s chapter on buildings (Cabeza et al. 2022) documents that low-carbon construction methods — compressed-earth blocks substituting for cement masonry; fly-ash cement substituting for Portland cement; bamboo, locally-sourced stone, and engineered timber substituting for energy-intensive imports; passive solar design substituting for active cooling — generate approximately 1.5 times the direct employment per rupee of capital deployed, because the substituted materials are labour-intensive rather than energy-intensive in their production. The UNEP International Resource Panel’s buildings-sector analysis (UNEP International Resource Panel 2020) is directionally consistent. At a 50% adoption rate for low-carbon materials across the new-library construction programme — itself a conservative assumption relative to GRIHA / IGBC ratings now standard in public construction tenders — the green-jobs increment is approximately **40,000 additional direct person-years** over the decade, or approximately **4,000 additional steady-state workers** in low-carbon materials manufacturing, processing, and on-site application.

Combining the construction and green-jobs estimates, the convergence CapEx supports approximately **35,000 to 40,000 direct construction-sector jobs sustained across the decade**, with a full employment multiplier of approximately **75,000 jobs** across the supply chain and consumption-induced channels. These are durable, geographically-distributed, and skill-graded jobs — concentrated in precisely the states (the four Central Zonal Council states and the eastern states) where the library-density gap is widest and where construction-sector employment is itself a developmental priority.

The construction unit-cost assumptions underlying these scenarios are consistent with the Central

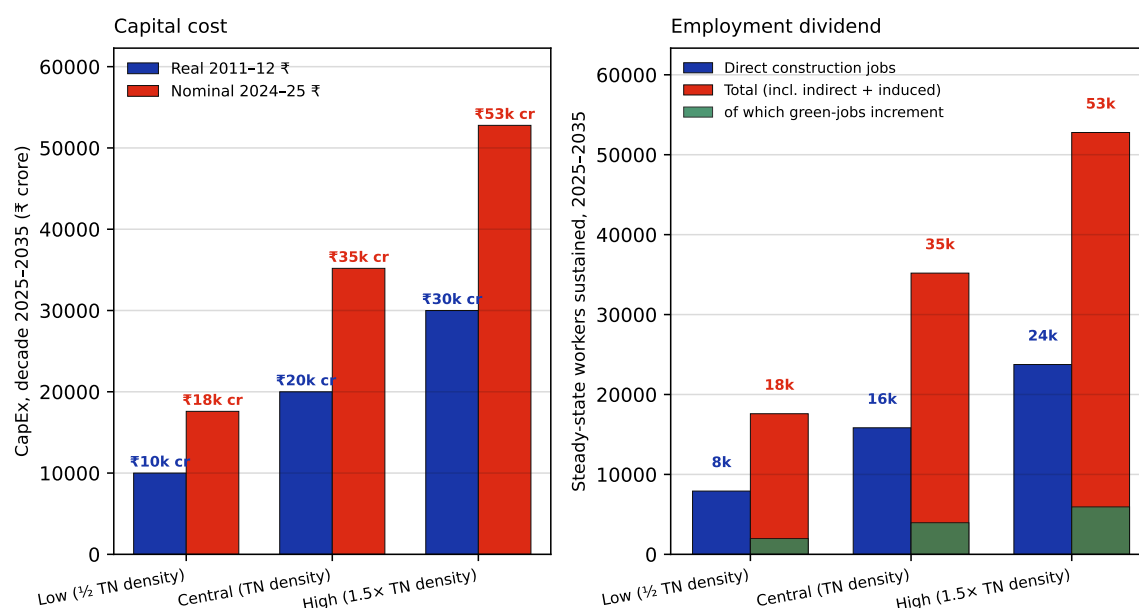


Figure 3: Three-scenario sensitivity for the public-library CapEx programme, 2025–2035. Low scenario: 50% of TN density (~19,000 new libraries; ₹10,000 crore real). Central scenario: TN density (~38,000 new libraries; ₹20,000 crore real). High scenario: 150% of TN density (~57,000 new libraries; ₹30,000 crore real). Bars show person-years of direct and total employment sustained across the decade; cost-to-Union-Budget share noted under each scenario.

Public Works Department's Plinth Area Rates for institutional buildings (Type IV) at the latest CPWD notification, which sit in the range of ₹28,000 to ₹35,000 per square metre of built-up area for institutional construction including basic IT and electrical fit-out. The blended ₹52 lakh per new library is derived from a portfolio of approximately 100 square metres for village/branch libraries, 250 square metres for taluka libraries, and 1,000 square metres for district libraries, weighted by population coverage. Per-square-metre sizing follows international library-design benchmarks (Latimer and Niegaard 2007). State PWD rates vary by approximately $\pm 15\%$ around CPWD baselines; sensitivity to this variation is incorporated in the low/high scenario bands.

1.5 Sixteenth Finance Commission grants: the immediate fiscal instrument

The fiscal-capacity argument is sharpened by the Sixteenth Finance Commission's award, tabled in Parliament on 1 February 2026 (Sixteenth Finance Commission, Government of India 2026). The Commission has recommended grants of approximately **₹7.9 lakh crore to India's local bodies over the five-year period 2026–27 to 2030–31**, comprising ₹4.4 lakh crore for Rural Local Bodies and ₹3.6 lakh crore for Urban Local Bodies. Of these grants, 80% are basic and 20% performance-linked; the basic component is further split half tied (to drinking water, sanitation, and solid-waste management) and half untied.

A back-of-envelope locates the convergence cost within this fiscal instrument. The first five years of the convergence path — roughly half of the cumulative ₹77,000 crore in today's terms — is approximately **₹38,500 crore over 2026–27 to 2030–31**. As a share of the Sixteenth Finance Commission's local-body award, this is approximately **4.9%**. As a share of the *untied* component of the basic grant (50% of 80% of ₹7.9 lakh crore = ₹3.16 lakh crore), it is approximately **12%**. Recommendations 5–8 of §7 below are therefore actionable within the existing FC16 grant architecture: nothing additional is required at

the Centre. What is required is a sub-classification of the untied basic grant — or a new tied category alongside water and sanitation — for public-library expenditure at the local-body level. The fiscal instrument is in place. The allocative decision is not.

1.6 Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI): the dormant central capex pipe

The Sixteenth Finance Commission grant architecture, however, is not the only central capex instrument relevant to library infrastructure. Under the Fifteenth Finance Commission framework (2021–26), the Government of India has progressively shifted central transfers from untied Finance Commission grants toward conditional, sector-tied capital schemes. The principal vehicle is the **Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI)** scheme — 50-year interest-free loans from the Centre to state governments for capital infrastructure, operating at approximately ₹1.5 lakh crore per year (Ministry of Finance, Government of India 2025b).

SASCI has been actively deployed in the cultural sector. The Ministry of Culture and Tourism enumerated, in a Lok Sabha answer dated 11 August 2025 (Ministry of Culture and Tourism, Government of India 2025), seven mandate areas of the Ministry — “Archaeological sites, Museums and its artefacts, **Public Libraries**, Promotion and dissemination of Performing Arts, Buddhist and Tibetan studies, International Cultural Relation and construction of cultural complexes” — and named SASCI alongside Swadesh Darshan (SD and SD 2.0), Challenge Based Destination Development (CBDD), Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual, Heritage Augmentation Drive (PRASHAD), and Assistance to Central Agencies (ACA) as the central capex pipes for this domain. The same answer documents specific SASCI-funded projects in Bihar alone — Karamchat Eco-Tourism Hub (₹49.51 crore sanctioned), Saharsa Matsyagandha Lake Development (₹97.61 crore sanctioned) — totalling ₹147.12 crore for two destinations.

The pattern is structurally important. Public libraries are explicitly within the Ministry of Culture’s enumerated mandate, yet no SASCI / SD / CBDD / PRASHAD / ACA project anywhere in the Annexure to the LS answer funds a public library. The available SASCI cultural sub-tranche has flowed entirely to tourism and heritage destinations — eco-tourism hubs, lake developments, Buddhist circuits, spiritual circuits, ASI-protected monuments — but not to the library system that the same Ministry administers and that the Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation coordinates.

The implications are concrete:

- The Centre has the **capex pipe** (SASCI, ₹1.5 lakh crore per year).
- The Centre has the **legal authority** (libraries are a named Ministry of Culture mandate).
- The Centre has the **disbursement infrastructure** (state-wise SASCI flows are already operational, including in Rajasthan, Bihar, Karnataka and other library-developing states).
- The Centre has the **precedent** (₹147 crore to two Bihar tourism projects under the same scheme architecture).

What is missing is the **allocative decision** to designate a SASCI sub-tranche for public library construction. This is a discretionary Ministry of Culture / Department of Expenditure decision — not a legislative change, not a constitutional amendment, not a Finance Commission re-design. The estimated CapEx requirement for an all-India Tamil-Nadu-density network (₹20,000 crore real, ₹35,000 crore nominal) is approximately **2.3% of one year’s SASCI envelope**, spread over a decade. As a

share of SASCI cultural-sector outflow, it is approximately one order of magnitude larger than the current tourism allocations — meaningful at scheme level but not at SASCI-aggregate level.

For state governments planning library investment, the SASCI dormancy is consequential: it means the Centre's largest available capex instrument is structurally unavailable for libraries until designated. The state-government-led convergence path established in §5.1–§5.5 holds independently of any SASCI activation, but a designated SASCI library sub-tranche would compress the network build-out from a decade to five-to-seven years and free state borrowing headroom for other priorities. The institutional logic for that designation — that libraries are upstream of corpus sovereignty, are positively externalising public goods, and are within the same Ministry as the heritage infrastructure SASCI already funds — sits in §6.2 below.

1.7 Sixteenth Finance Commission monitoring infrastructure

That such an allocative decision is plausible is supported by the parallel architecture for monitoring it. The Ministry of Panchayati Raj's Panchayat Advancement Index portal (pai.gov.in), built on the eGramSwaraj data platform, already tracks a basket of infrastructure indicators at gram-panchayat level, including the existence of panchayat library facilities. The data infrastructure required to operationalise both grant disbursement (against verified panchayat-level library investment) and outcome monitoring (against verified library service provision) is therefore already partially in place. It requires only that the relevant ministries — Panchayati Raj, Culture, and Education — be authorised by the Finance Ministry to use it for this purpose.

1.8 What the combined number means

The combined envelope — recurrent expenditure to bring all-India per-capita library spending to the projected Tamil Nadu 2035 standard, plus capital expenditure to build the physical network at Tamil Nadu density — is approximately **₹44,000 crore in real 2011–12 ₹**, or **₹77,000 crore in nominal terms**, over the decade 2025–2035. Figure 7 places this envelope alongside three reference quantities of Indian public finance. Located in the actual fiscal accounts of the Indian state:

#| label: fig-context #| fig-cap: “Decade-cumulative convergence cost (₹77,000 crore nominal) in the context of comparable Indian public expenditure quantities. Convergence cost is one decade; the comparators are single-year fiscal flows or one-off capital outlays. Log scale.” #| fig-width: 7 #| fig-height: 3.2

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("States' social-sector expenditure (one year)", 17_00_000, C_INK),] labels = [b[0] for b in bench]
values = [b[1] for b in bench] colors = [b[2] for b in bench]
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color='white', lw=0.5) for bar, v in zip(bars, values): ax.text(v * 1.05, bar.get_y() + bar.get_height()/2,
f'₹{v/100000:.2f} lakh cr',
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